Kwikby Banner Carousel: Review and Revised Plan

Review of the banner carousel proposal for a general, custom-built multi-vendor marketplace, with the changes recommended before building.

What works

- **Tiers.** Separating paid, earned and platform placements is the right structure. It also makes the rules easy to explain to vendors.
- **Admin approval and asset checks.** Both are essential. Checks in the browser only help the vendor; the server must enforce the same rules again.
- **Category-scoped carousels.** This matters for a general marketplace. A baby-clothes banner should not appear for electronics buyers. A category field can be added to the hero slot model now at no extra cost.
- **Reporting.** Impressions, clicks and click-through rate are the minimum vendors will expect if they pay.

What to change

1. **Do not rank paid and quality in one formula.** A formula such as bid times weight plus rating times weight lets a high bidder with weak service outrank a well-rated shop. The two scales also need normalising, or one always dominates. Use hard quotas instead: for example, one paid slot and two earned slots out of four. Within the earned slots, rank by a capped performance score so that no single metric can outweigh the rest.
2. **Use fixed-price time blocks first.** An auction adds complexity before there is demand. Start with a flat price per day in a category, and add bidding later if vendors ask for it.
3. **Make earned-tier thresholds fair to new shops.** A rule such as "rating above 4.5, under 1% returns, over 100 monthly sales" excludes every new shop, so the earned tier would favour established sellers only. Add a small new-shop allowance in the earned slots for shops under 90 days old.
4. **Label paid placements as "Sponsored."** The original proposal left this out. It protects shoppers' trust and is a consumer-protection expectation in many markets. Confirm the exact requirement with a legal adviser.

5. **Be careful with attributed sales from UTM parameters alone.** They overcount when shoppers return later, and they miss purchases made on another device. Use a stated attribution window, such as seven days from the last click, and filter bot traffic out of impressions before reporting.
6. **Plan for the privacy and cold-start problems of personalisation.** Showing banners based on browsing history needs consent under the cookie policy. New visitors have no history, so they need a default set of banners.
7. **Payments need a real provider first.** The platform has no real card processing yet, so paid placements cannot go live until that is in place. Keep advertising fees separate from the commission ledger, which tracks sales.

Suggested plan

Each page's carousel has four slots:

- **One platform slot** for Kwikby's own campaigns.
- **One sponsored slot** sold at a fixed price per day in a chosen category.
- **Two earned slots**, ranked by a capped performance score, with a new-shop allowance.

The one-shop-per-fortnight rule still applies across all four slots. Start with the homepage and the category pages.

Decisions needed

- Should paid placements take at most one of the four slots, or more?
- Start with fixed daily prices, or with bidding?
- Are paid placements allowed on category pages, or only on the homepage?